Build a Two-Week Preparedness Kit

Build a portable go-bag for leaving quickly, then build a separate two-week supply for staying at home. A full two-week home supply is not meant to be carried during an evacuation.

△ CAUTION — PREVENT HARM

Local direction comes first: hazards, climate, water availability, and evacuation conditions vary. Follow local emergency-management and public-health authorities whenever their current instructions or recommended quantities differ from this checklist.

1. WRITE DOWN THE PLANNING NUMBERS

Household members: adults ____ + children ____ = **people** ____

Animals (list species and number): _____

Two-week planning period: **14 days** | Go-bag planning period set by local authorities: ____ days

Use each person's real daily needs—not an average—when the table says “daily use.” Round up and allow for spills, delays, or damaged supplies where space and budget permit.

Need	Two-week home calculation	Quantity to obtain
Water	1 gallon × ____ people × 14 days = ____ gallons minimum. Plan more for pregnancy, illness, hot climates, and hygiene or medical needs. Add each animal's usual daily water × 14.	People: ____ gal Animals: ____ gal
Shelf-stable food	3 meals × ____ people × 14 days = ____ person-meals, adjusted to normal portions. Add snacks or formula as needed.	____ meals Other: _____
Medications and health supplies	Each person's daily use × 14, **only when permitted** by the prescriber, pharmacist, insurer, and law. Include prescriptions, over-the-counter items, and supplies used with medicines or medical devices.	Person/item: _____ Qty: ____ Refills due: ____
Sanitation and hygiene	Each person's daily use × 14 for diapers, menstrual products, incontinence items, wipes, and other consumables. Add soap, toilet paper, trash bags, ties, and a safe backup toilet method.	_____ Qty: ____
Lighting	One flashlight or headlamp for each person who can use one, plus area lighting. Calculate replacement batteries or recharge cycles for 14 days from the device instructions. Prefer lights to candles.	Lights: ____ Batteries/cycles: ____

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Need	Two-week home calculation	Quantity to obtain
Communications	At least one battery-powered or hand-crank weather radio; a charged phone/device for each user; paper contact and meeting plans; local map.	Radios: ____ Devices: ____
Power	For every essential device, list watt-hours, battery type, or recharge cycles needed across 14 days. Prioritize medical, mobility, communication, and refrigeration needs; make a power-outage plan with the utility and care team.	Device: _____ Batteries/charges: ____
Cash	Choose an amount for 14 days of essential local purchases; include small bills and coins. Do not keep more than you can store securely.	$____ total
Documents	One protected paper or offline copy set for the household: identification, contacts, prescriptions, insurance, financial and medical information, plans, and animal records.	Paper sets: ____ Offline copies: ____
Climate and clothing	One season-appropriate change/layer set per person, then add blankets, rain protection, sun protection, sturdy shoes, heating/cooling aids, and other items for local conditions.	Sets: ____ Other: _____
Animal supplies	Each animal's usual daily food, water, medicine, litter, and other consumables × 14. Include bowls, sanitation supplies, records, identification, carrier, leash, harness, or other safe restraint.	Food: ____ Water: ____ Medicine/other: ____

Water is the minimum priority: CDC and the American Red Cross recommend storing at least **1 gallon per person per day**; the Red Cross lists a **two-week supply for home** and a **three-day supply for evacuation**. Your local authority may set a different evacuation amount.

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2. PACK THE PORTABLE GO-BAG SEPARATELY

Pack only what each person can safely move, or arrange help. Do **not** delay an evacuation to collect supplies.

- ☐ Water and ready-to-eat food for the evacuation period recommended by local authorities—not the entire two-week home supply
- ☐ Essential medicines, copies of prescriptions, medical and accessibility supplies, and a list of health needs
- ☐ Phone, charging cable, power bank, battery/hand-crank radio, flashlight or headlamp, and spare batteries
- ☐ Identification and protected copies of contacts, plans, insurance, and other essential records
- ☐ Small bills, keys, local map, basic first aid, hygiene items, masks, sturdy shoes, and climate layers
- ☐ For children and animals: essential food, water, medicines, comfort items, identification, and safe restraints

Label bags. Keep medical, communication, mobility, sensory, and animal items beside the person or animal who needs them. Review transport, shelter, and backup-power arrangements with support networks before an emergency.

3. CHOOSE FOOD AND SUPPLIES PEOPLE CAN USE

- ☐ Choose shelf-stable foods that require little water, refrigeration, or cooking. Include a manual can opener and utensils.
- ☐ Plan for allergies, intolerances, religious or cultural diets, diabetes or other medical diets, infant feeding, and texture or feeding assistance. Check every label; do not assume an emergency food is safe.
- ☐ Include glasses, hearing-aid batteries, communication boards, mobility-device parts, chargers, adaptive utensils, service-animal supplies, and sensory or comfort items as applicable.
- ☐ Ask a clinician or pharmacist how to obtain and safely store an emergency medication supply; never change doses or use expired medicine unless an authorized official specifically directs it.

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4. STORE SAFELY AND ROTATE

- ☐ Keep supplies accessible, dry, and protected from pests, flooding, extreme temperatures, and household chemicals. Do not block an exit. Split heavy water and food among smaller containers or locations.
- ☐ Use unopened commercially bottled water by its printed date. For water you fill yourself, use sanitized food-grade containers, label the date, keep them cool and out of direct sunlight, and replace the water every 6 months. Never use a container that held toxic chemicals.
- ☐ Keep food in a cool, dry place in closed containers. Discard cans that are leaking, bulging, badly dented, or heavily rusted. When in doubt about food safety, throw it out; never taste food to test it.
- ☐ Store medicines exactly as their labels or pharmacist direct, secured from children and animals. Keep batteries and power banks dry and at manufacturer-recommended temperatures; inspect for swelling, leaks, corrosion, or damage.
- ☐ Every 6 months—and after using the kit—check water replacement dates, food and medicine dates, batteries and charge levels, document accuracy, clothing fit, animal needs, and seasonal hazards. Use and replace items before they expire when safe to do so.

Next check date: ____ / ____ / _____ Checked by: _____

Build a Two-Week Preparedness Kit — continued

5. BUILD IT IN STAGES

If buying everything now is not possible, start with what you already have. Do not take on unsafe debt or skip current medicines, food, rent, or utilities.

1. **This week:** pack evacuation essentials and three days of water, food, medicines, sanitation items, and lighting.

2. **Next:** add one day per person and animal at a time until the home supply reaches 14 days.

3. **Then:** add communications, backup power, documents, cash, climate, accessibility, and comfort items in the order most critical to your household.

4. **Keep it ready:** rotate supplies into normal use, replace them gradually, and revisit the plan when household needs or local guidance change.

Ask local emergency management, public health, utilities, schools, disability organizations, food assistance programs, animal services, and community groups about local guidance or assistance.

Go deeper: See **Section 3 — Evacuation & Shelter**, **Section 4 — Water, Food & Cooking**, **Section 7 — Hazard Guides**, and **Section 8 — Plans & Records** for detailed procedures.

SOURCES

Sources: Ready.gov, “Build A Kit,” “Personal Needs,” “Individuals with Disabilities,” and “Pets and Animals”; CDC, “Creating and Storing an Emergency Water Supply”; American Red Cross, “Survival Kit Supplies”; FDA, “Food.” Accessed 2026-09-25.